

Question ID f52cc78c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: f52cc78c

Text 1

Polar bears sustain themselves primarily by hunting seals on the Arctic sea ice, but rising ocean temperatures are causing the ice to diminish, raising concerns about polar bear population declines as these large predators’ seal-hunting habitats continue to shrink. A 2020 study examining polar bear populations across the Arctic concluded that populations affected by sea-ice loss are at great risk of extinction by the end of the twenty-first century.

Text 2

Monitoring carried out by researchers from the Norwegian Polar Institute shows that the polar bear population on the Arctic archipelago of Svalbard remains stable and well nourished despite rapidly declining sea ice in recent years. The researchers attribute this population’s resilience in part to a shift in feeding strategies: in addition to hunting seals, the Svalbard polar bears have begun relying on a diet of reindeer meat and birds’ eggs.

Based on the texts, how would the researchers in Text 2 most likely respond to the conclusion presented in the underlined portion of Text 1?

- A. By noting that it neglects the possibility of some polar bear populations adapting to changes in their environment
- B. By suggesting that it is likely incorrect about the rates at which warming ocean temperatures have caused sea ice to melt in the Arctic
- C. By asserting that it overlooks polar bear populations that have not yet been affected by loss of seal-hunting habitats
- D. By arguing that it fails to account for polar bears’ reliance on a single seal-hunting strategy

ID: f52cc78c Answer

Correct Answer:

A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. Text 2 describes how the Svalbard polar bears have adapted to the loss of sea ice by diversifying their diet and feeding on reindeer and seabird eggs, resulting in a “stable and well nourished” population despite environmental challenges. This counters the underlined claim that polar bears facing a loss of sea ice are at “great risk of extinction” by the end of the century.

Choice B is incorrect. Text 2 does not challenge the fact that sea ice is rapidly declining in the Arctic due to warming ocean temperatures. In fact, it states that the Svalbard polar bears have faced “rapidly declining sea ice in recent years.” Choice C is incorrect. The claim in Text 1 is specific to polar bear populations affected by the loss of seal hunting habitats, so unaffected populations are irrelevant to the claim. Also, Text 2 doesn’t mention any polar bear populations that haven’t yet been affected by loss of seal hunting habitats. It focuses on a population that has been affected by sea-ice loss but has managed to survive and thrive nevertheless. Choice D is incorrect. Text 2 doesn’t imply that polar bears rely on a single seal-hunting strategy. In fact, the researcher in Text 2 would say that Text 1 fails to account for polar bears’ ability to develop other hunting strategies and food sources.

Question Difficulty:

Question ID f878693b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: f878693b

Text 1

In 1954 George Balanchine choreographed a production of *The Nutcracker*, a ballet by Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky. It has since become a tradition for hundreds of dance companies in North America to stage *The Nutcracker* each year. But the show is stuck in the past, with an old-fashioned story and references, so it should no longer be produced. Ballet needs to create new traditions if it wants to stay relevant to contemporary audiences.

Text 2

The Nutcracker is outdated, but it should be kept because it’s a holiday favorite and provides substantial income for some dance companies. Although it can be behind the times, there are creative ways to update the show. For example, Debbie Allen successfully modernized the story. Her show *Hot Chocolate Nutcracker* combines ballet, tap, hip-hop, and other styles, and it has been gaining in popularity since it opened in 2009.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1?

- A. By questioning the idea that the story of *The Nutcracker* is stuck in the past and by rejecting the suggestion that contemporary audiences would enjoy an updated version
- B. By agreeing that contemporary audiences have largely stopped going to see performances of *The Nutcracker* because it’s so old-fashioned
- C. By pointing out that most dance companies could increase their incomes by offering modernized versions of *The Nutcracker*
- D. By suggesting that dance companies should consider offering revised versions of *The Nutcracker* instead of completely rejecting the show

ID: f878693b Answer

Correct Answer:

D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1. Text 1 begins by noting the success of *The Nutcracker* but then claims that the ballet is "stuck in the past" and should "no longer be produced." Text 2 begins by conceding that *The Nutcracker* is indeed outdated but argues that it should continue to be performed, states that the show can be updated to include more contemporary dance styles, and provides an example of one such modernized version, *Hot Chocolate Nutcracker*. Hence, the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1 by suggesting that dance companies should consider offering revised versions of *The Nutcracker* instead of completely rejecting the show.

Choice A is incorrect because the author of Text 2 advocates for using creative ways to update *The Nutcracker* and therefore wouldn't respond to the underlined claim by rejecting the suggestion that contemporary audiences would enjoy an updated version. Choice B is incorrect because although the authors of both texts claim that *The Nutcracker* is outdated, neither text

suggests that contemporary audiences have largely stopped attending productions of the show. On the contrary, Text 2 states that *The Nutcracker* is a holiday favorite and generates substantial income for some dance companies. Choice C is incorrect because although Text 2 provides an example of a contemporized version of *The Nutcracker*, the text doesn't suggest that offering modernized versions is a way to increase income for most dance companies. Rather, the author of Text 2 suggests that offering modernized versions is a way to make the ballet discussed in Text 1 feel less outdated.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 8889d6e2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 8889d6e2

Text 1

An excavation in Chiquihuite Cave in central Mexico has upended the belief that approximately 13,000 years ago, a group known as the Clovis people were the first human inhabitants of North America. More than 200 crude stone tools were found embedded in a layer of earth that is up to 33,150 years old, revealing that humans occupied the cave thousands of years before the Clovis people reached the continent.

Text 2

The objects uncovered in Chiquihuite Cave are intriguing, but it is premature to characterize them as tools. The stone pieces are so roughly shaped that they may have simply fractured from rocks during natural geological activity in the cave. Moreover, their unearthing has thus far not been accompanied by discoveries of other signs of human activity or even traces of human DNA from surfaces.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1?

- A. By suggesting that it draws a plausible connection between two groups of people but will need to be confirmed with further study
- B. By asserting that it rests on an assumption about the stone pieces that is not sufficiently supported by available evidence
- C. By acknowledging that it will most likely be proved correct when the stone pieces undergo more detailed analysis
- D. By pointing out that it fails to account for evidence that the Clovis people were active on the continent as early as is commonly thought

ID: 8889d6e2 Answer

Correct Answer:

B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the underlined claim about the Clovis people in Text 1. Text 1 explains that the idea that the Clovis people were the first human inhabitants of North America has been overturned by the unearthing of stone tools in Chiquihuite Cave in Mexico. The tools were found in a layer of earth that is over 33,000 years old—much older than the Clovis people’s arrival 13,000 years ago. The text ends with the claim that the tools reveal that humans lived in the cave long before the Clovis people reached the continent. Text 2, on the other hand, disputes the idea that the stone pieces are definitely tools. Text 2 states that the pieces are so roughly shaped that they may have simply naturally broken off from rocks and, moreover, that no other signs of human activity have been found in the cave. In other words, Text 2 argues that there is no proof yet that humans made the pieces as tools or were even present in the cave. Therefore, the author of Text 2 would most likely say that the claim that humans occupied Chiquihuite Cave long before the Clovis people reached North America rests on an assumption about the stone pieces—that they are human-made tools—that is not sufficiently supported by available evidence.

Choice A is incorrect because Text 1 doesn't claim that human inhabitants of Chiquihuite Cave and the Clovis people had any connection; the author of Text 1 focuses only on the timing of each group's presence in North America. Further, the author of Text 2 makes no mention of the Clovis people and indicates that it isn't clear yet that any human group did inhabit Chiquihuite Cave. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in Text 2 suggests that the author believes the stone pieces probably are human-made tools and will be confirmed as such by further analysis; instead, the author of Text 2 emphasizes the current lack of evidence of human activity in the cave. Choice D is incorrect because Text 2 focuses on the issue of characterizing the stone pieces as tools made by humans, not on the timing of any particular group's activity in North America; further, Text 1 seems to support the common belief that the Clovis people reached North America 13,000 years ago and challenges only the idea that they were the continent's first inhabitants. Therefore, there's no reason to think the author of Text 2 would say that the author of Text 1 overlooks evidence that the Clovis people were active as early as is commonly thought.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 27d9bb69

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 27d9bb69

Text 1

Many studies in psychology have shown that people seek out information even when they know in advance that they have no immediate use for it and that they won't directly benefit from it. Such findings support the consensus view among researchers of curiosity: namely, that curiosity is not instrumental but instead represents a drive to acquire information for its own sake.

Text 2

While acknowledging that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, Rachit Dubey and colleagues ran an experiment to test whether emphasizing the usefulness of scientific information could increase curiosity about it. They found that when research involving rats and fruit flies was presented as having medical applications for humans, participants expressed greater interest in learning about it than when the research was not presented as useful.

- Based on the texts, how would Dubey and colleagues (Text 2) most likely respond to the consensus view discussed in Text 1?
- A. By suggesting that curiosity may not be exclusively motivated by the desire to merely acquire information
 - B. By conceding that people may seek out information that serves no immediate purpose only because they think they can use it later
 - C. By pointing out that it is challenging to determine when information-seeking serves no goal beyond acquiring information
 - D. By disputing the idea that curiosity can help explain apparently purposeless information-seeking behaviors

ID: 27d9bb69 Answer

Correct Answer:

A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The researchers in Text 2 recognize that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, but showed that this motivation can still be affected by other factors, like whether or not the information is expected to be useful or not. This suggests that other desires may play a part in driving people to acquire information.

Choice B is incorrect. The consensus view in Text 1 is that people acquire information regardless of whether they think they can use it later. Dubey and colleagues acknowledge this fact (so they don't claim people seek out information "only" because it might be useful later). Choice C is incorrect. This choice misreads the results of Dubey and colleagues' study in Text 2. Neither text discusses the difficulty of determining the motivation for information-seeking. Choice D is incorrect. This choice contradicts Text 2, which starts with Dubey and colleagues "acknowledging that acquiring information is a powerful motivator" (i.e., agreeing that curiosity explains the seeking of apparently purposeless information). The research in Text 2 simply suggests that more than just curiosity can motivate information-seeking behavior when the information has a purpose.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID c19b2f77

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: c19b2f77

Text 1

Little is known about how plate tectonics—wherein slabs of Earth’s crust move over, under, away from, and against one another—began. Some researchers contend that tectonic movements began around 3 billion years ago, often noting that computer models of Earth’s mantle temperature at the time indicate that the mantle would have been sufficiently molten to enable the plates to move.

Text 2

Ultimately, any plausible claim about the inception of tectonic movement must rest on empirical evidence from the geological record. Researcher Wriju Chowdhury and his team analyzed the geochemistry of zircon crystals to gain insight into the chemical composition of the magma from which the crystals formed and, based on the data, compellingly argue that plate tectonics may have been occurring as early as 4.2 billion years ago.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to what “some researchers contend” as described in Text 1?

- A. By suggesting that the temperature of Earth’s mantle 3 billion years ago was likely insufficient to allow for the level of tectonic movement predicted by computer models
- B. By distinguishing between computer models of Earth’s mantle temperature that reliably predict the onset of plate tectonics and those that do not
- C. By indicating that computer models of Earth’s mantle temperature are still being improved such that new models tend to be much more reliable than their predecessors
- D. By asserting that a more definitive form of evidence than the computer models suggests a different timeline for the onset of plate tectonics on Earth

ID: c19b2f77 Answer

Correct Answer:
D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to what the researchers mentioned in Text 1 contend. Text 1 discusses the lack of knowledge of how plate tectonics on Earth began. Text 1 also mentions researchers who contend that movements of tectonic plates began around 3 billion years ago. As support for this assertion, these researchers cite computer models (which are simulations, not empirical evidence) of the temperature in Earth’s mantle that show that at that time, the mantle would have been sufficiently molten for plates to move. However, the author of Text 2 asserts that empirical evidence from the geological record is necessary to make plausible claims about when tectonic movement began. Text 2 mentions an analysis performed by Wriju Chowdhury and his team of the geochemistry of zircon crystals (which would constitute empirical evidence). Chowdhury and his team argue, based on this analysis, that tectonic plates may have begun to move as early as 4.2 billion years ago. Therefore, since the author of Text 2 would consider Chowdhury et al.’s empirical evidence

to be more conclusive than the computer models cited in Text 1, the author of Text 2 would most likely assert that a more definitive form of evidence than the computer models suggests a different timeline for the onset of plate tectonics on Earth.

Choice A is incorrect because the author of Text 2 makes no claims about the temperature of Earth's mantle and therefore wouldn't argue that the temperature of Earth's mantle 3 billion years ago was insufficient to allow tectonic movement. Choice B is incorrect because the author of Text 2 claims that empirical evidence is needed to fix the earliest date of tectonic movement. Computer models are simulations, not empirical evidence, so the author of Text 2 wouldn't distinguish between different kinds of computer models but would instead argue that no computer models can reliably predict the onset of plate tectonics. Choice C is incorrect because the author of Text 2 wouldn't consider any computer model to be able to provide evidence to support a plausible claim about tectonic movement, no matter how much such models were improved. The author of Text 2 would only accept empirical evidence.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID faee8ec7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: faee8ec7

Text 1

It seems clear that emotional contagion (the unintentional transfer of an emotional state from one person to another) requires physical interaction and the observation of body language. After all, research shows that talking to someone who is smiling and expressing positive feelings often causes people to respond in a comparably positive way. Similarly, displays of nervous fidgeting have been found to prompt others to begin behaving more nervously, too.

Text 2

In an experiment using a social networking service, Zeyao Yang and Emilio Ferrara found evidence of emotional contagion in text-based online interactions. The researchers discovered that reading social media posts that expressed a positive outlook led people to make more positive posts themselves, while posts with a negative emotional tone led people to make more negative posts.

Based on the texts, what would the researchers in Text 2 most likely say about the claim underlined in Text 1?

- A. It perpetuates a flawed understanding of emotional contagion, because there isn't enough evidence to suggest that smiling is a sign of emotional contagion.
- B. It reflects an incomplete view of emotional contagion, because this phenomenon can occur even without in-person interaction.
- C. It's fairly persuasive, because studies attempting to identify emotional contagion in situations without in-person interaction have thus far yielded unclear results.
- D. It's mostly accurate, because the social networking study confirmed that emotional contagion primarily occurs in response to negative emotions like nervousness.

ID: faee8ec7 Answer

Correct Answer:

B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it represents how the researchers in Text 2 would most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1. Text 1 begins by asserting that the unintended transfer of feelings from one person to another, known as emotional contagion, seems to rely on both people being physically present and able to observe body language. Text 1 then references research that supports this assertion. Text 2 describes an experiment conducted by the researchers Yang and Ferrara in which they found evidence of emotional contagion in the absence of physical interaction, namely through text-based interactions on social media. The researchers in Text 2 wouldn't completely agree with what is asserted in the underlined portion of Text 1 (that emotional contagion seems to require physical proximity), because their study, which used a social media networking service, found that physical interaction isn't the only way that emotional contagion can take place. Thus, the researchers in Text 2 would most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1 by stating that it reflects an incomplete view of emotional contagion, because the phenomenon can occur without an in-person interaction.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the researchers in Text 2 would likely agree that the underlined statement in Text 1 perpetuates a flawed conclusion that emotional contagion requires physical interaction, Text 2 doesn't address what the researchers thought about smiling as a sign of emotional contagion. Choice C is incorrect because the researchers in Text 2 wouldn't say that the underlined claim in Text 1 is fairly persuasive. According to Text 2, the researchers conducted a study that found emotional contagion didn't require physical interaction, because they found evidence of it in text-based online interactions. Choice D is incorrect because neither of the texts claim that emotional contagion primarily occurs when a person is exposed to negativity. Instead, Text 1 claims that physical interaction is required for emotional contagion to occur, and Text 2 describes a study that suggests emotional contagion can occur in text-based online interactions.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID f653b273

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: f653b273

Text 1

A tiny, unusual fossil in a piece of 99-million-year-old amber is of the extinct species *Oculudentavis khaungraae*. The *O. khaungraae* fossil consists of a rounded skull with a thin snout and a large eye socket. Because these features look like they are avian, or related to birds, researchers initially thought that the fossil might be the smallest avian dinosaur ever found.

Text 2

Paleontologists were excited to discover a second small fossil that is similar to the strange *O. khaungraae* fossil but has part of the lower body along with a birdlike skull. Detailed studies of both fossils revealed several traits that are found in lizards but not in dinosaurs or birds. Therefore, paleontologists think the two creatures were probably unusual lizards, even though the skulls looked avian at first.

- Based on the texts, what would the paleontologists in Text 2 most likely say about the researchers’ initial thought in Text 1?
- A. It is understandable because the fossil does look like it could be related to birds, even though *O. khaungraae* is probably a lizard.
 - B. It is confusing because it isn’t clear what caused the researchers to think that *O. khaungraae* might be related to birds.
 - C. It is flawed because the researchers mistakenly assumed that *O. khaungraae* must be a lizard.
 - D. It is reasonable because the *O. khaungraae* skull is about the same size as the skull of the second fossil but is shaped differently.

ID: f653b273 Answer

Correct Answer:
A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it reflects what the paleontologists in Text 2 would most likely say about what the researchers in Text 1 initially thought. Text 1 focuses on the discovery of a strange fossil consisting of the skull of the extinct species *Oculudentavis khaungraae*. According to Text 1, the fossil has features that appear to be avian, or related to birds, which led researchers to initially think that the fossil might be a very small avian dinosaur. Text 2 begins by noting the discovery of a second fossil similar to the one discussed in Text 1, then explains that based on detailed studies of both fossils, paleontologists think that the two creatures were probably unusual lizards, even though the skulls appeared avian at first. This suggests that the paleontologists in Text 2 recognize that the fossils do indeed look like they could be related to birds. For this reason, the paleontologists in Text 2 would most likely say that the initial thought of the researchers in Text 1—that the fossil was avian—is understandable, even if the fossil is probably not avian but rather is from a lizard.

Choice B is incorrect because Text 2 indicates that the fossils initially looked avian, so the paleontologists described in Text 2 wouldn’t be confused by the researchers in Text 1 initially thinking that *O. khaungraae* might be related to birds. The

paleontologists would find that initial thought understandable, not confusing. Choice C is incorrect because Text 1 never mentions lizards, so it wouldn't make sense for the paleontologists in Text 2 to say that the researchers in Text 1 mistakenly assumed that *O. khaungraae* must be a lizard. Choice D is incorrect. Although the paleontologists in Text 2 might agree that the initial thought of the researchers in Text 1 was reasonable, nothing in Text 2 suggests that the two skulls were shaped differently.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID ab56a107

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: ab56a107

Text 1

Digital art, the use of digital technology to create or display images, isn't really art at all. It doesn't require as much skill as creating physical art. "Painting" with a tablet and stylus is much easier than using paint and a brush: the technology is doing most of the work.

Text 2

The painting programs used to create digital art involve more than just pressing a few buttons. In addition to knowing the fundamentals of art, digital artists need to be familiar with sophisticated software. Many artists will start by drawing an image on paper before transforming the piece to a digital format, where they can apply a variety of colors and techniques that would otherwise require many different traditional tools.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the claims of the author of Text 1?

- A. By arguing that a piece of art created digitally can still be displayed traditionally
- B. By explaining that it's actually much harder to use a tablet and stylus to create art than to use paint and a brush
- C. By insisting that digital art requires artistic abilities and skill even if it employs less traditional tools
- D. By admitting that most digital artists don't think fundamental drawing skills are important

ID: ab56a107 Answer

Correct Answer:

C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would respond to the claims in Text 1. Both texts address skills needed to produce digital art. Text 1 claims that digital art doesn't require the same amount of skill as creating physical art and that "the technology is doing most of the work." Text 2 states that digital art requires "knowing the fundamentals of art" and that many digital artists begin their work on paper and then transfer it to a digital format using "sophisticated software" and "a variety of colors and techniques." Therefore, the author of Text 2 would most likely insist that digital art requires artistic abilities even if it employs less traditional tools.

Choice A is incorrect because neither text discusses nondigital means of displaying art. Choice B is incorrect because the author of Text 2 doesn't address whether it's harder to use a tablet and stylus than it is to use paint and a brush. Text 2 does argue that digital art requires skills that aren't part of the traditional methods for producing art, but the text doesn't address relative difficulty. Choice D is incorrect because the author of Text 2 states that digital artists still need to know "the fundamentals of art" and that many digital artists begin their work by drafting on paper before transferring the work to a digital format.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 12d81fc1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 12d81fc1

Text 1

Because literacy in Nahuatl script, the writing system of the Aztec Empire, was lost after Spain invaded central Mexico in the 1500s, it is unclear exactly how meaning was encoded in the script’s symbols. Although many scholars had assumed that the symbols signified entire words, linguist Alfonso Lacadena theorized in 2008 that they signified units of language smaller than words: individual syllables.

Text 2

The growing consensus among scholars of Nahuatl script is that many of its symbols could signify either words or syllables, depending on syntax and content at any given site within a text. For example, the symbol signifying the word *huipil* (blouse) in some contexts could signify the syllable “pil” in others, as in the place name “Chipiltepec.” Thus, for the Aztecs, reading required a determination of how such symbols functioned each time they appeared in a text.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely characterize Lacadena’s theory, as described in Text 1?

- A. By praising the theory for recognizing that the script’s symbols could represent entire words
- B. By arguing that the theory is overly influenced by the work of earlier scholars
- C. By approving of the theory’s emphasis on how the script changed over time
- D. By cautioning that the theory overlooks certain important aspects of how the script functioned

ID: 12d81fc1 Answer

Correct Answer:

D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Lacadena’s theory is that Nahuatl script symbols signified syllables, but the consensus described in Text 2 is that they can signify either symbols or full words, depending on the context. So the author of Text 2 would likely consider Lacadena’s theory too simplistic: it’s missing the importance of the context in determining the meaning of a symbol.

Choice A is incorrect. This conflicts with Text 1’s description of Lacadena’s theory. Lacadena’s theory is that Nahuatl script symbols signified syllables. Choice B is incorrect. This conflicts with Text 1’s description of Lacadena’s theory. Text 1 states that Lacadena’s theory differed from what earlier scholars believed. Choice C is incorrect. We can’t infer that this is how the author of Text 2 would characterize Lacadena’s theory. Neither text mentions how or even if the script changed over time.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 03080769

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 03080769

Text 1

Philosopher G.E. Moore’s most influential work entails the concept of common sense. He asserts that there are certain beliefs that all people, including philosophers, know instinctively to be true, whether or not they profess otherwise: among them, that they have bodies, or that they exist in a world with other objects that have three dimensions. Moore’s careful work on common sense may seem obvious but was in fact groundbreaking.

Text 2

External world skepticism is a philosophical stance supposing that we cannot be sure of the existence of anything outside our own minds. During a lecture, G.E. Moore once offered a proof refuting this stance by holding out his hands and saying, “Here is one hand, and here is another.” Many philosophers reflexively reject this proof (Annalisa Coliva called it “an obviously annoying failure”) but have found it a challenge to articulate exactly why the proof fails.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to proponents of the philosophical stance outlined in Text 2?

- A. By agreeing with those proponents that Moore’s treatment of positions that contradict his own is fundamentally unserious
- B. By suggesting that an instinctive distaste for Moore’s position is preventing external world skeptics from constructing a sufficiently rigorous refutation of Moore
- C. By arguing that if it is valid to assert that some facts are true based on instinct, it is also valid to assert that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct
- D. By pointing out that Moore would assert that external world skepticism is at odds with other beliefs those proponents must unavoidably hold

ID: 03080769 Answer

Correct Answer:

D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. According to the author of Text 1, Moore’s definition of common sense—things we instinctively know are true—includes the belief that we all “exist in a world with other objects.” The author of Text 1 describes this notion as both “obvious” and “groundbreaking.” So it’s safe to infer that the author would observe that Moore would respond to external world skeptics by arguing that since everyone instinctively knows that things exist outside of their own minds, then external world skepticism must be wrong.

Choice A is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. If anything, the author of Text 1 seems to agree with Moore. Choice B is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. The author of Text 1 never mentions external world skeptics directly, let alone why they have a hard time refuting Moore’s position. Choice C is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external

world skeptics. Text 1’s presentation of Moore’s concept of common sense only includes the idea that some facts are true based on instinct—it doesn’t mention the idea that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID c8a2af72

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: c8a2af72

Text 1

French Impressionist artist Edgar Degas insisted that his paintings be kept in their original frames after they were sold. Like many Impressionist painters, Degas used painted frames that stood in contrast to the gold frames frequently seen at the Paris Salon, a prestigious art exhibition that was sponsored by the French government and promoted traditional painting styles. Impressionist painters likely chose these colorful frames to distinguish themselves from what was considered conventional at the time.

Text 2

Impressionist painters often focused on the interplay of color and light in their works. As such, those Impressionists who placed their works in painted frames instead of the more traditional gold ones did so for aesthetic reasons: a frame’s color was likely chosen because it would harmonize with the colors or subjects in a painting. Gold, conversely, could distract from the subtleties in a painted scene.

Based on the texts, both authors would most likely agree with which statement?

- A. Gold frames were considered especially desirable by those who purchased works from Impressionist painters.
- B. The colors in an Impressionist painting were often chosen to complement the colors of the frame it would be placed in.
- C. Many Impressionist painters were intentional about the frames they selected for their works.
- D. Degas’s preferred framing style was different from that of most Impressionist painters.

ID: c8a2af72 Answer

Correct Answer:

C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the statement about the use of painted frames in Impressionist painting that both authors would be most likely to agree with. Text 1 discusses painter Edgar Degas’s insistence that his works remain in their original painted frames, which contrasted with the gold frames that were typical of the Paris art scene at the time. The text then argues that the preference of Degas and other French Impressionist painters for colorful frames can likely be attributed to their desire "to distinguish themselves from what was considered conventional at the time." Text 2 also notes that Impressionist painters "placed their works in painted frames" but argues that they probably did so for a purely aesthetic reason: to ensure that "the frame’s color...would harmonize with the colors or subjects in a painting." Though differing on Impressionist painters’ rationale for using painted frames, the authors of both texts would agree that many Impressionist painters were intentional about the frames they selected for their works.

Choice A is incorrect because neither text suggests that gold frames were considered desirable by those purchasing Impressionist works. Indeed, it can be inferred from the fact that Impressionist painters used painted frames that those who purchased those works wouldn’t have had a strong preference for gold frames. Choice B is incorrect because neither text suggests that Impressionist painters chose colors for their paintings based on planned frame colors. Indeed, Text 2 states that frame colors

were chosen to "harmonize with the colors or subjects in a painting," implying that the color scheme of paintings predated and took precedence over the choice of the colors of frames. Choice D is incorrect because Text 1 presents Degas's preference for painted frames as being typical of Impressionist painters' attitudes toward the framing of their works. Moreover, although Text 2 doesn't specifically discuss Degas, it concurs with Text 1's assertion that these painters preferred painted frames. Thus, both texts position painted frames as a hallmark of French Impressionist painting, not as a deviation from it.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 9a94eb77

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 9a94eb77

Text 1

One challenge faced by researchers studying global urbanization is that countries may define urban settlements differently. Many countries define urban settlements based on the number of people living in them. However, countries do not all use the same number; for example, Iceland uses a minimum population of 200, while the Netherlands uses 20,000. Other countries use a combination of population and other factors. This variation makes it difficult for researchers to compare aspects of urbanization in different countries.

Text 2

Recently, a group of six international organizations developed global definitions of common types of settlements. The group developed a new measure called the “degree of urbanization.” This new measure establishes global criteria used to define three types of settlements (cities, towns, and rural areas) and allows researchers to better understand global urbanization rates.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the problem presented in Text 1?

- A. By recommending that a specific institution should further investigate the problem
- B. By suggesting that researchers focus on topics besides urbanization
- C. By supplying additional ways in which urbanization research is difficult
- D. By noting that a possible solution to the problem is available

ID: 9a94eb77 Answer

Correct Answer:

D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because Text 2 presents a possible solution to the problem identified in Text 1—that is, how disparities in the criteria used by different countries to define urban settlements make it "difficult for researchers to compare aspects of urbanization in different countries." Text 2 describes the creation of a shared framework for studying global urbanization: "global definitions of common types of settlements" and a "new measure called the ‘degree of urbanization’" that "allows researchers to better understand global urbanization rates."

Choice A is incorrect. Although Text 2 mentions "a group of six international organizations" that developed criteria and a measure related to settlements and urbanization, no organization or institution is singled out to perform further research. Choice B is incorrect because both texts are about urbanization research and neither mentions any other fields of study. Choice C is incorrect. Text 2 discusses a possible solution to the terminological problem in global urbanization research, not additional areas of difficulty in the field.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID eae66bf9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: eae66bf9

Text 1

In 2021, a team led by Amir Siraj hypothesized that the Chicxulub impactor—the object that struck the Yucatán Peninsula sixty-six million years ago, precipitating the mass extinction of the dinosaurs—was likely a member of the class of long-period comets. As evidence, Siraj cited the carbonaceous chondritic composition of samples from the Chicxulub impact crater as well as of samples obtained from long-period comet Wild 2 in 2006.

Text 2

Although long-period comets contain carbonaceous chondrites, asteroids are similarly rich in these materials. Furthermore, some asteroids are rich in iridium, as Natalia Artemieva points out, whereas long-period comets are not. Given the prevalence of iridium at the crater and, more broadly, in geological layers deposited worldwide following the impact, Artemieva argues that an asteroid is a more plausible candidate for the Chicxulub impactor.

Based on the texts, how would Artemieva likely respond to Siraj’s hypothesis, as presented in Text 1?

- A. By insisting that it overestimates how representative Wild 2 is of long-period comets as a class
- B. By arguing that it does not account for the amount of iridium found in geological layers dating to the Chicxulub impact
- C. By praising it for connecting the composition of Chicxulub crater samples to the composition of certain asteroids
- D. By concurring that carbonaceous chondrites are prevalent in soil samples from sites distant from the Chicxulub crater

ID: eae66bf9 Answer

Correct Answer:

B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Siraj’s hypothesis is that the Chicxulub impactor was a long-period comet. But Artemieva points to the iridium found in the crater and in “geological layers that were deposited worldwide after the impact” as evidence that it was actually an asteroid, not a long-period comet.

Choice A is incorrect. We can’t infer that this is how Artemieva would respond to Siraj’s hypothesis. Text 2 never discusses whether Wild 2 is representative of long-period comets in general. Rather, Text 2 presents Artemieva’s argument that the Chicxulub impactor was an asteroid, not a long-term comet. Choice C is incorrect. We can’t infer that this is how Artemieva would respond to Siraj’s hypothesis. Siraj’s hypothesis doesn’t make this connection: rather, Siraj hypothesizes that the Chicxulub impactor was a long-term comet. Choice D is incorrect. We can’t infer that this is how Artemieva would respond to Siraj’s hypothesis. “Soil samples from sites distant from the Chicxulub crater” is too vague. Only soil samples from sites that are connected to the impact in some way are involved in either hypothesis.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID f1c9d2c1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: f1c9d2c1

Text 1

Stage lighting theorist Adolphe Appia was perhaps the first to argue that light must be considered alongside all the various elements of a stage to create a single, unified performance. Researcher Kelly Bremner, however, has noted that Appia lacked technical expertise in the use of light in the theater. As a result of Appia’s inexperience, Bremner argues, Appia’s theory of light called for lighting practices that weren’t possible until after the advent of electricity around 1881.

Text 2

Adolphe Appia was not an amateur in the practice of lighting. Instead, it is precisely his exposure to lighting techniques at the time that contributed to his theory on the importance of light. When working as an apprentice for a lighting specialist in his youth, Appia observed the use of portable lighting devices that could be operated by hand. This experience developed his understanding of what was possible in the coordination of elements on the stage.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the claim about Appia’s level of technical expertise made by Bremner in Text 1?

- A. Many lighting technicians dismissed Appia’s ideas about light on the stage.
- B. Appia likely gained a level of technical expertise during his time as an apprentice.
- C. Theater practitioners who worked with Appia greatly admired his work.
- D. Appia was unfamiliar with the use of music and sound in theater.

ID: f1c9d2c1 Answer

Correct Answer:

B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The author of Text 2 directly contradicts Bremner’s claim that Appia lacked technical expertise by stating that Appia was “not an amateur in the practice of lighting.” His experience as a lighting specialist’s apprentice would have, the author of Text 2 argues, allowed Appia to “[develop] his understanding of what was possible” with the elements of theatrical design.

Choice A is incorrect. Neither text describes how other lighting technicians responded to Appia’s ideas. Furthermore, this claim isn’t relevant to Bremner’s evaluation of Appia’s technical expertise. Choice C is incorrect. Neither text mentions anything about the opinions of theater practitioners who worked with Appia, so this answer choice does not relate to the claim about Appia’s level of technical expertise made by Bremner in Text 1. Choice D is incorrect. Neither text mentions anything about Appia’s familiarity with or ignorance of the use of music and sound in theater. Both focus on his expertise (or lack thereof) in lighting.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 82c05b34

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 82c05b34

Text 1

The live music festival business is growing in event size and genre variety. With so many consumer options, organizers are finding ways to cement festival attendance as a special experience worth sharing. This phenomenon is linked to the growing “experiential economy,” where many find it gratifying to purchase lived experiences. To ensure a profitable event, venues need to consider the overall consumer experience, not just the band lineup.

Text 2

Music festival appearances are becoming a more important part of musicians’ careers. One factor in this shift is the rising use of streaming services that allow access to huge numbers of songs for a monthly fee, subsequently reducing sales of full-length albums. With this shift in consumer behavior, musicians are increasingly dependent on revenue from live performances.

Based on the texts, both authors would most likely agree with which statement?

- A. Consumers are more interested in paying subscription fees to stream music than in attending music festivals in person.
- B. Consumers’ growing interest in purchasing experiences is mostly confined to the music industry.
- C. Changing consumer behaviors are leading to changes in music-related businesses.
- D. The rising consumer demand for live music festivals also generates higher demand for music streaming platforms.

ID: 82c05b34 Answer

Correct Answer:

C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. Both authors mention how consumer behaviors have shifted, and how this affects different aspects of the music industry. Text 1 states that consumers enjoy purchasing “lived experiences,” and that this influences how organizers design music festivals. Text 2 states that consumers are using streaming services more, and that this reduces album sales and increases the importance of live performances for musicians.

Choice A is incorrect. Neither text claims that consumers prefer streaming to festivals, or that these are mutually exclusive options. Text 1 implies that festivals are popular and profitable, and Text 2 never suggests that streaming services diminish the demand for live music. Choice B is incorrect. This choice misreads Text 1, which identifies music festivals as just one example of a broader trend of purchasing “lived experiences.” Text 2 doesn’t mention growing interest in purchasing experiences, in the music industry or otherwise. Choice D is incorrect. Neither text establishes a cause/effect relationship between the demand for festivals and the demand for streaming platforms. Text 1 does not mention streaming platforms at all, and Text 2 does not imply that streaming platforms benefit from the popularity of festivals.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID e1befb41

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: e1befb41

Text 1

In a study of the benefits of having free time, Marissa Sharif found that the reported sense of life satisfaction tended to plateau when participants had two hours of free time per day and actually began to fall when they had five hours of free time per day. After further research, Sharif concluded that this dip in life satisfaction mainly occurred when individuals spent all their free time unproductively, such as by watching TV or playing games.

Text 2

Psychologist James Maddux cautions against suggesting an ideal amount of free time. The human desire for both free time and productivity is universal, but Maddux asserts that individuals have unique needs for life satisfaction. Furthermore, he points out that there is no objective definition for what constitutes productivity; reading a book might be considered a productive activity by some, but idleness by others.

Based on the texts, how would Maddux (Text 2) most likely respond to the conclusion Sharif (Text 1) reached after her further research?

- A. By acknowledging that free time is more likely to enhance life satisfaction when it is spent productively than when it is spent unproductively
- B. By challenging the reasoning in Text 1, as it has not been proved that productivity commonly contributes to individuals' life satisfaction
- C. By warning against making an overly broad assumption, as there is no clear consensus in distinguishing between productive and unproductive activities
- D. By claiming that the specific activities named in Text 1 are actually examples of productive activities rather than unproductive ones

ID: e1befb41 Answer

Correct Answer:

C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it characterizes how Maddux would most likely respond to the conclusion Sharif reached after her research. Text 1 describes Sharif's study of the benefits of free time, saying that the reported sense of satisfaction plateaued at two hours per day and began to decline at five hours per day. Further research led Sharif to conclude that time spent doing tasks she defines as unproductive, such as watching TV or playing games, correlated with a drop in life satisfaction. However, in Text 2 Maddux says that there is no objective definition of what constitutes productive behavior, giving the example that reading a book might be considered productive by some but unproductive by others. It can be inferred that Maddux would also assert that whether watching TV or playing games is productive or unproductive is a matter of subjective judgment. Thus,

Maddux would most likely caution against making an overly broad assumption, as there is no clear consensus in distinguishing between productive and unproductive activities.

Choice A is incorrect because Maddux asserts that individuals have unique needs for life satisfaction: some may want to spend that time productively, others unproductively, and what counts as productive is subjective. Therefore, Maddux would likely not consider it universally true that free time is more likely to enhance life satisfaction when it is spent productively. Choice B is incorrect because the study described in Text 1 concerns whether free time contributes to life satisfaction, not whether productivity contributes to life satisfaction. The dip in life satisfaction that Sharif claims to observe in Text 1 happens only after five hours, and mainly if the time is spent unproductively—that is, two hours of free time spent productively might increase life satisfaction just as much as two hours spent unproductively. Choice D is incorrect because Maddux holds the opinion that whether an activity is productive or unproductive is subjective and depends on the individual; therefore, he would most likely claim that watching TV or playing games might be productive for some and unproductive for others.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 059f7201

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 059f7201

Text 1

Graphic novels are increasingly popular in bookstores and libraries, but they shouldn't be classified as literature. By definition, literature tells a story or conveys meaning through language only; graphic novels tell stories through illustrations and use language only sparingly, in captions and dialogue. Graphic novels are experienced as series of images and not as language, making them more similar to film than to literature.

Text 2

Graphic novels present their stories through both language and images. Without captions and dialogue, readers would be unable to understand what is depicted in the illustrations: the story results from the interaction of text and image. Moreover, Alison Bechdel's *Fun Home* and many other graphic novels feature text that is as beautifully written as the prose found in many standard novels. Therefore, graphic novels qualify as literary texts.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the overall argument presented in Text 1?

- A. By asserting that language plays a more important role in graphic novels than the author of Text 1 recognizes
- B. By acknowledging that the author of Text 1 has identified a flaw that is common to all graphic novels
- C. By suggesting that the story lines of certain graphic novels are more difficult to understand than the author of Text 1 claims
- D. By agreeing with the author of Text 1 that most graphic novels aren't as well crafted as most literary works are

ID: 059f7201 Answer

Correct Answer:

A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the argument presented in Text 1. In arguing that graphic novels shouldn't be classified as literature and are more comparable to film, Text 1 claims that language plays a relatively limited role in graphic novels: images, not language, are the primary means by which graphic novels tell their stories, and language is used "only sparingly"—that is, comparatively very little—in the form of captions and dialogue. However, the author of Text 2 asserts that language in graphic novels is as equally vital for conveying meaning as images are, since without captions and dialogue, readers wouldn't be able to make sense of the narrative. Moreover, the author of Text 2 argues that there are many graphic novels that are "beautifully written" and whose use of language is as accomplished as any standard novel. Because Text 1 argues that language is subordinate to images in graphic novels, whereas Text 2 highlights how language is an essential component of a graphic novel's storytelling, it can reasonably be inferred that the author of Text 2 would say that language plays a more important role in graphic novels than the author of Text 1 recognizes.

Choice B is incorrect. Although Text 1 indicates that graphic novels shouldn't be classified as literature based on their limited use of language, there's no indication that the author of Text 1 considers this limited use of language as a flaw, just that it doesn't fit

the particular definition of "literature" proposed in the text. Even if Text 1 had suggested that their use of language was a common flaw of graphic novels, the author of Text 2 emphasizes how many graphic novels are "beautifully written," and would therefore say that their use of language is exemplary, not that it is flawed. Choice C is incorrect because Text 1 doesn't claim that the story lines of graphic novels are generally relatively easy to understand; in addition, Text 2 argues that given their dependence on the interaction of image and text, the stories of graphic novels would be incomprehensible if their captions and dialogue were removed, not that the story lines of some graphic novels are more difficult to understand than Text 1 acknowledges. Choice D is incorrect because the author of Text 1 doesn't imply that graphic novels aren't well crafted, only that they use language too sparingly to fit the definition of "literature," and that their use of images to convey stories makes them more comparable to film than to literature. Even if the author of Text 1 had implied that most graphic novels aren't well crafted, Text 2 refers to the fact that many graphic novels are as beautifully written—that is, well crafted—as many standard novels; thus, it wouldn't be accurate to say that the author of Text 2 would agree with the author of Text 1 that most graphic novels aren't well crafted.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 8de51658

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 8de51658

Text 1

The idea that time moves in only one direction is instinctively understood, yet it puzzles physicists. According to the second law of thermodynamics, at a macroscopic level some processes of heat transfer are irreversible due to the production of entropy—after a transfer we cannot rewind time and place molecules back exactly where they were before, just as we cannot unbreak dropped eggs. But laws of physics at a microscopic or quantum level hold that those processes *should* be reversible.

Text 2

In 2015, physicists Tiago Batalhão et al. performed an experiment in which they confirmed the irreversibility of thermodynamic processes at a quantum level, producing entropy by applying a rapidly oscillating magnetic field to a system of carbon-13 atoms in liquid chloroform. But the experiment “does not pinpoint ... what causes [irreversibility] at the microscopic level,” coauthor Mauro Paternostro said.

Based on the texts, what would the author of Text 1 most likely say about the experiment described in Text 2?

- A. It would suggest an interesting direction for future research were it not the case that two of the physicists who conducted the experiment disagree on the significance of its findings.
- B. It provides empirical evidence that the current understanding of an aspect of physics at a microscopic level must be incomplete.
- C. It is consistent with the current understanding of physics at a microscopic level but not at a macroscopic level.
- D. It supports a claim about an isolated system of atoms in a laboratory, but that claim should not be extrapolated to a general claim about the universe.

ID: 8de51658 Answer

Correct Answer:

B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Author 1 describes the puzzle that physicists still can’t solve: at a microscopic level, the “laws of physics” suggest that we should be able to reverse processes that are not reversible at a macroscopic level (and, maybe, turn back time!). The experiment confirmed that those processes are not reversible even on the microscopic level, but it didn’t explain why. This supports Author 1’s point that physicists still don’t fully understand how things work at a microscopic level—maybe the laws need to be revised.

Choice A is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to the experiment. Text 2 does name two of the physicists involved in the experiment, but it never suggests that they disagree on anything. Choice C is incorrect. This is the opposite of what the experiment suggests. The experiment confirmed that the macroscopic-level law (“these things can’t be reversed—like time”) was still true on the microscopic level—meaning it supports the current understanding of physics at a

macroscopic level. Choice D is incorrect. We can't infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to the experiment. Neither text makes this distinction between laboratory findings and the way the universe works in general.

Question Difficulty:

Medium

Question ID 7bf79a90

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 7bf79a90

Text 1

Microbes are tiny organisms in the soil, water, and air all around us. They thrive even in very harsh conditions. That’s why Noah Fierer and colleagues were surprised when soil samples they collected from an extremely cold, dry area in Antarctica didn’t seem to contain any life. The finding doesn’t prove that there are no microbes in that area, but the team says it does suggest that the environment severely restricts microbes’ survival.

Text 2

Microbes are found in virtually every environment on Earth. So it’s unlikely they would be completely absent from Fierer’s team’s study site, no matter how extreme the environment is. There were probably so few organisms in the samples that current technology couldn’t detect them. But since a spoonful of typical soil elsewhere might contain billions of microbes, the presence of so few in the Antarctic soil samples would show how challenging the conditions are.

Based on the texts, Fierer’s team and the author of Text 2 would most likely agree with which statement about microbes?

- A. Most microbes are better able to survive in environments with extremely dry conditions than in environments with harsh temperatures.
- B. A much higher number of microbes would probably be found if another sample of soil were taken from the Antarctic study site.
- C. Microbes are likely difficult to detect in the soil at the Antarctic study site because they tend to be smaller than microbes found in typical soil elsewhere.
- D. Most microbes are probably unable to withstand the soil conditions at the Antarctic study site.

ID: 7bf79a90 Answer

Correct Answer:

D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement about microbes with which Fierer’s team (Text 1) and the author of Text 2 would most likely agree. Text 1 states that microbes usually thrive in very harsh conditions, and so Fierer’s team was surprised when samples collected from an extremely cold and dry area of Antarctica didn’t appear to contain any life. Fierer’s team says that though this doesn’t conclusively prove there are no microbes in the area, it suggests that microbes would have a notably difficult time surviving in the environment. The author of Text 2 says it’s unlikely that there would be no microbes at all in the Antarctic study site from which Fierer’s team retrieved soil samples and that there may have been hard-to-detect microbes in the samples. However, the presence of only a few microbes in the Antarctic samples rather than the billions found in a typical soil sample (which would presumably be much easier to detect) would illustrate conditions in the Antarctic soil that make it difficult for microbes to thrive. Since Fierer’s team says that the seeming absence of microbes in the Antarctic samples suggests an unusually harsh environment and the author of Text 2 says that even if there are a few undetectable microbes in the samples, the relatively tiny number of microbes would also suggest an unusually harsh environment, then Fierer’s team and the author of Text 2 would most likely agree that most microbes are unable to withstand the soil conditions at the Antarctic study site.

Choice A is incorrect. The samples taken by Fierer’s team were from an area of Antarctica that is described in part as extremely dry, and these samples didn’t appear to have any life. Therefore, even though these samples also came from an extremely cold area, Fierer’s team wouldn’t argue based on the evidence available that microbes were better able to survive in dry conditions than in areas with harsh temperatures. Moreover, the author of Text 2 says that microbes are found in virtually every environment on Earth but doesn’t compare dry environments and harsh environments. Choice B is incorrect. Nothing in Text 1 indicates that another collection of samples from the Antarctic study site might yield different results from the samples already taken by Fierer’s team. The author of Text 2 does state that microbes are found in virtually every environment on Earth and suggests that new technology may be better able to detect so few microbes in a soil sample, but the author of Text 2 concludes that the unusual absence of microbes in the Antarctic samples is evidence of the harsh Antarctic environment. Therefore, there is no reason to believe that the author of Text 2 thinks that another sample drawn from that same harsh environment would yield a much higher number of microbes. Choice C is incorrect. The author of Text 2 does speculate that there may have been so few microbes in the Antarctic samples that current technology couldn’t detect them, but the author doesn’t speculate that this is due to the size of the microbes. Moreover, nothing that Fierer’s team says suggests that they are speculating that their samples might have microbes that are smaller than microbes in typical soil samples.

Question Difficulty:

Medium